

Baptism By Immersion

prc-baptism-by-immersion

Sacraments · Baptism · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Baptism is administered by full immersion as a public confession of faith and identification with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection.

In plain language

The statement makes three claims at once: that baptism is done by full immersion, that it is a public confession of faith, and that it pictures the believer's identification with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection. The original-language evidence answers these unevenly. The death, burial, and resurrection part is on solid ground. In Romans 6 Paul says all who were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death, and that we were buried with him through baptism so that we might walk in newness of life. Colossians 2 says the same, that we were buried with him in baptism and also raised with him through faith. The Greek verb for 'buried with him' (synthapto) appears in only these two verses in the whole canon, so its meaning is anchored right here, and the link to faith is explicit. So the union with the dying and rising Christ, and the role of faith, are clearly carried by the words. The immersion part is the disputed piece. The root Greek verb behind baptize, 'to dip' (bapto), simply means to dip, and the standard lexicon gives the core sense of 'to baptize' (baptizo) as to dip, immerse, sink. In the Old Testament Greek the same verb describes Naaman dipping ('to dip', taval in Hebrew) seven times in the Jordan. In Acts 8 Philip and the official both go down into ('to go down', katabaino, with 'into', eis) the water and come up out of ('to come up', anabaino, with 'out of', ek) the water, the same down-and-up wording used when Jesus comes up out of the water in Mark 1, and John baptized at Aenon because there was much water (hydor) there. All of this fits immersion well. But the same word family is also used for washings that did not require going under. A Pharisee is surprised Jesus did not first wash (baptizo) before a meal, the word covers the rinsing of cups and kettles (baptismos), and Hebrews uses it for the various ceremonial washings of the law, many of which were done by sprinkling ('to sprinkle', zaraq in Hebrew). Most tellingly, Israel is called baptized (baptizo) in the cloud and the sea even though they crossed on dry ground and were never submerged. Because the verb covers cleansing by application as well as by dipping, and because the texts that actually command baptism never state how much water is used, the picture of burial and rising favors immersion strongly but the words do not require it to the exclusion of pouring. For that reason the overall statement reads as genuinely contested on the question of mode, while its symbolism and its link to faith stand firmly.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H2236	זָרַק,	zaraq	to scatter	70
H2881	טָבַל,	taval	to dip	32
G0305	ἀναβαίνω	anabaino	to ascend	82
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	82
G0908	βάπτισμα	baptisma	baptism	23

G0909	βαπτισμός	baptismos	baptism	5
G0911	βάπτω	bapto	to dip	4
G1453	ἐγείρω	egeirō	to arise	
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	1,824
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	945
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabaino	to come/go down	82
G4916	συνθάπτω	synthapto	be buried with	4
G5204	ὕδωρ	hydor	water	80

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition bundles three claims and the original-language word evidence answers them unequally. The identification of the baptized believer with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection is firmly grounded in the completed past-tense passive forms parsed in the store: 'we were buried with' (synetaphemen, Strong's G4916, parsed as a 2nd aorist, that is a completed past action, passive, first person plural, in Romans 6:4) and the participle 'having been buried with' (syntaphentes) together with 'you were raised with' (synegerthete, G4916, 2nd aorist passive participle, nominative plural masculine, in Colossians 2:12) place burial-with and raising-with at the center of the act, and the verb 'to be buried with' (synthapto) occurs in only these two verses in the whole canon. The mode claim of full immersion is the contested element. The root verb 'to dip' (bapto, G0911) means to dip (Luke 16:24, John 13:26, Revelation 19:13), the brief lexicon glosses 'to immerse or wash' (baptizo, G0907) as to dip, immerse, sink, and 'baptism, the act of immersion' (baptisma, G0908) literally as immersion, and the going-down and coming-up narration of Acts 8:38-39 plus Mark 1:10 ('to go down' katabaino, 'to come up' anabaino, 'out of' ek, 'water' hydor) and the much-water note of John 3:23 cohere with immersion. But the same word group names ceremonial washings that need not submerge: 'to wash' (baptizo) of pre-meal hand washing (Luke 11:38) and 'a washing' (baptismos, G0909) of rinsing cups (Mark 7:4) and of the various ceremonial washings of the law applied to flesh (Hebrews 9:10, Hebrews 6:2), while 1 Corinthians 10:2 calls Israel baptized in the cloud and sea without going under. No anchor or command text states the mode. Because the mode is lexically defensible but not lexically mandated, the bundled proposition is materially contested on mode while strong on the union symbolism and the faith confession.

Scripture

Rom.6.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G1519 εἰς

Force. Paul asks 'or do you not know that as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus were baptized into his death' (e agnoeite hoti hosoi ebaptisthemen eis Christon lesoun eis ton thanaton autou ebaptisthemen), twice using the completed past tense passive of 'to baptize' (baptizo) (the store parses it G0907, V-API-1P, that is a completed past, passive, first person plural, 'we were baptized') with the preposition 'into' (eis) plus the receiving form of the noun. The construction frames baptism as incorporation into Christ and specifically into his death. This grounds the death-identification element of the proposition, but the clause speaks of the referent and effect of the act, union with the dying Christ, not of the physical mode of administering water.

Rom.6.4 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4916 συνθάπτω, G1453 ἐγείρω

Force. 'We were buried therefore with him through baptism into death, in order that just as Christ was raised from the dead' (synetaphemen oun auto dia tou baptismatos eis ton thanaton, hina hosper egerthe Christos ek nekron). The store parses 'we were buried with' (synetaphemen) as G4916 V-2API-1P, a 2nd aorist (a completed past action) passive, first person plural, 'we were buried with', and the following purpose clause moves to walking in 'newness of life' (kainoteti zoes) patterned on the resurrection. 'To be buried with' (synthapto) occurs in only two verses of the whole canon, this one and Colossians 2:12, so its sense is fixed by these baptism contexts. The burial-and-raising structure is the load-bearing image and matches a going-down and coming-up motion, the strongest original-language support for the immersion reading, though the figure is union with Christ rather than a stated rubric of submersion.

Col.2.12 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4916 συνθάπτω, G0909 βαπτισμός

Force. 'Having been buried with him in baptism, in which also you were raised with him through faith in the working of God who raised him from the dead' (syntaphentes auto en to baptismo, en ho kai synergethete dia tes pisteos) pairs being co-buried in baptism with being co-raised through faith in the working of God who raised Christ from the dead. The store parses 'having been buried with' (syntaphentes) as G4916 V-2APP-NPM, a 2nd aorist (completed past action) passive participle, nominative plural masculine, 'having been buried with'. The explicit mention of 'faith' (pisteos) supports the confession-of-faith element of the proposition, and the buried-and-raised pairing reinforces the death-burial-resurrection identification. Note that this verse is the one place the canon uses 'a washing' (baptismos, G0909) of Christian baptism, the same noun used of Jewish ceremonial washings in Mark 7:4 and Hebrews 9:10. The verse describes meaning and instrument, not the geometry of how much water covers the body.

Acts.8.38 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2597 καταβαίνω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Force. 'They both went down into the water, both Philip and the eunuch, and he baptized him' (katebesan amphoteroi eis to hydor, ho te Philippos kai ho eunouchos, kai ebaptisen auton), where 'he baptized' (ebaptisen) is parsed G0907 V-AAI-3S, a completed past active, third person singular, 'he baptized'. Both men go down ('to go down', katabaino, G2597) into ('into', eis) the water before the baptizing, and verse 39 has them come up ('to come up', anabaino, G0305) out of ('out of', ek) the water, the same verbs confirmed token by token in the store. This pair of 'into' (eis) and 'out of' (ek) with verbs of going-down and coming-up is the narrative datum most consistent with immersion. It is suggestive but not decisive, since going down to and up from a body of water describes approach and departure and would also fit a baptism performed while standing in shallow water.

Mark.1.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0305 ἀναβαίνω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Force. At the baptism of Jesus the store confirms 'coming up out of the water' (anabainon ek tou hydatos), with G0305 'to come up' (anabaino), G1537 'out of' (ek), and G5204 'water' (hydor) present in the verse, the same going-down and coming-up vocabulary as Acts 8. This parallel narrative datum, where the one baptized comes up out of the water, strengthens the immersion-consistent reading, though here too the language describes the motion of the person relative to the water, not a prescribed quantity of water.

John.3.23 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Force. 'Now John also was baptizing in Aenon near Salim, because there was much water there' (en de kai ho ioannes baptizon en Aion engys tou Saleim, hoti hydata polla en ekei). The store confirms 'to baptize' (baptizo, G0907) with 'water' (hydor, G5204) and 'much, many' (polys, G4183), 'much water', at Aenon. The note that much water was present coheres with the immersion reading, since immersion needs a sufficient body of water, but the clause states a circumstance of the location rather than a rule for the mode, so it supports without mandating.

Acts.8.36 · **neutral** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5204 ὕδωρ, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. 'See, here is water; what prevents me from being baptized' (idou hydor, ti kolyei me baptisthenai). The eunuch points to available water as the only stated prerequisite for being baptized, with the completed past passive infinitive 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai, G0907). The text presents water plus the candidate's confessed readiness as sufficient and names no mode, which is neutral to the specific immersion claim while affirming that a body of water and a willing confessor are what the practice requires.

Luke.11.38 · **complicates** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. 'And the Pharisee, seeing it, marveled that he had not first washed before the meal' (ho de Pharisaios idon ethaumasen hoti ou proton ebaptisthe pro tou aristou), where the completed past passive of 'to wash' (baptizo, G0907) denotes the ritual washing expected before a meal, not a full-body submersion. The brief lexicon assigns this to sense 2 of the verb, to perform ablutions (ceremonial washings), wash oneself, bathe. This shows the verb itself can name a ceremonial washing short of immersion, which complicates the claim that the original word by itself fixes the mode as full immersion in every context.

Mark.7.4 · **complicates** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G0909 βαπτισμός

Force. 'And when they come from the marketplace, they do not eat unless they wash; and there are many other things they have received to hold, washings of cups and pitchers and copper vessels' (kai ap agoras ean me baptisontai ouk esthiousin, kai alla polla estin ha parelabon kratein, baptismous poterion kai xeston kai chalkion). The word group ('to wash', baptizo G0907, and 'a washing', baptisimos G0909) covers ceremonial washings of persons and of cups, pitchers, and kettles, items that were rinsed or sprinkled rather than necessarily plunged. The brief lexicon glosses 'a washing' (baptisimos) here as a dipping, washing, ceremonial cleansing. This is the clearest original-language evidence that the noun and verb do not by themselves entail full immersion, the reason the mode element is contested rather than settled.

Heb.9.10 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0909 βαπτισμός

Force. 'Only with foods and drinks and various washings, regulations of the flesh' (monon epi bromasin kai pomasin kai diaphorais baptismois, dikaiomata sarkos). The store confirms 'a washing' (baptisimos, G0909) used here of the various washings of the old covenant law applied to the flesh. Many of those washings in the law were performed by sprinkling or pouring (the cleansing rites of Leviticus and Numbers), so this verse shows the 'washing' word denoting a class of purifications whose mode was not uniform submersion. It complicates any inference that the baptism vocabulary by itself prescribes immersion.

1Cor.10.2 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Force. 'And all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea' (kai pantes eis ton Mousen ebaptisanto en te nephele kai en te thalasse). The store confirms 'to baptize' (baptizo, G0907) here with 'cloud' (nephele, G3507) and 'sea' (thalassa, G2281). Israel is said to have been baptized in the cloud and in the sea, yet the narrative has them pass through on dry ground while the cloud overshadowed and the sea stood as walls, so the people themselves were not submerged. This is a strong original-language complication: the verb can describe a water-and-cloud event of identification without literal submersion of the subjects, which blocks treating immersion as the necessary referent of 'to baptize' (baptizo).

Ezek.36.25 · complicates · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H2236 זָרַק,

Force. 'I will sprinkle clean water upon you and you shall be clean' ('to sprinkle, scatter', zaraq, H2236, confirmed in the store). This prophetic purification, reached as an OpenBible cross-reference from the Acts 8:36 baptism scene, pictures cleansing accomplished by casting or sprinkling water onto the person rather than by submerging the person, and 'to sprinkle' (zaraq) is one of the dominant purification verbs of the law (70 occurrences). It supplies an Old Testament pattern of cleansing-by-application that the New Testament baptism vocabulary does not exclude, which is why the mode question is left open by the words.

2Kgs.5.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2881 טָבַל,

Force. 'Naaman went down and dipped seven times in the Jordan' ('to dip', taval, H2881, glossed in the store as to dip, dip into, plunge). The Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) renders this Hebrew verb with the middle voice of 'to baptize' (baptizo), providing the clearest pre-Christian bridge for the word, where the action is plainly a full dipping in a river. This supports the immersion sense of the verb at its original root, even though 'to dip' (taval) elsewhere can name a dip that prepares a sprinkling rite, as when hyssop is dipped in blood or water in Leviticus 14:6 and Numbers 19:18.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.6.4	1Pet.3.21	openbible	27
Rom.6.3	Gal.3.27	openbible	28
Rom.6.3	1Cor.12.13	openbible	14
Col.2.12	Rom.6.3	openbible	25
Acts.8.36	Ezek.36.25	openbible	3
Acts.8.36	Titus.3.5	openbible	4
Acts.8.36	John.3.23	openbible	4
Acts.8.36	Acts.10.47	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Luke.11.38 · addressed

The verb 'to wash' (baptizo) here names the pre-meal washing the Pharisee expected, a ceremonial washing not requiring submersion (the brief lexicon places it in sense 2, to perform ceremonial washings, bathe). This is addressed by distinguishing the semantic range of the original word, which includes ritual washing, from its referent in the baptism texts. The complication does not overturn the union-with-Christ symbolism of Romans 6 and Colossians 2, but it does block the inference that the original word alone mandates full immersion, which is why the verdict on mode is disputed rather than affirmed.

Mark.7.4 · addressed

The application of 'to wash' (baptizo) and 'a washing' (baptismos) to washings of hands and of cups, pitchers, and kettles shows the word group covers acts performed by rinsing or sprinkling, not only by plunging. This is addressed by acknowledging that the original-language range is broad enough to admit non-immersive washing; the immersion reading therefore rests on the burial imagery of Romans 6 and Colossians 2, the going-down and coming-up narration of Acts 8 and Mark 1, and the root sense of 'to dip' (bapto), rather than on the bare word, leaving the mode lexically defensible but not lexically required.

Heb.9.10 · addressed

'A washing' (baptismos) here labels the various washings of the law, many of which Leviticus and Numbers perform by sprinkling or pouring. This is addressed by noting that the same noun used of Christian baptism in Colossians 2:12 elsewhere covers a class of purifications whose mode is not uniform submersion, so the noun does not by itself fix immersion. It deepens rather than removes the contest on mode.

1Cor.10.2 · addressed

Israel is said to be baptized in the cloud and the sea while passing through on dry ground, so the subjects were not submerged. This is addressed by treating it as decisive proof that 'to baptize' (baptizo) can describe an identifying water-and-cloud event without literal immersion of the persons, which is why the verb alone cannot carry the exclusive-immersion claim. The union and identification sense survives; the strict mode does not.

Concordance traversed

G0907, G0908, G0909, G0911, G4916, G5204, G1519, G1537, G2597, G0305, G1453, H2881, H2236

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

All anchor verses lie in the New Testament outside 3 John, so CBGM (the genealogical method behind the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) data is not in scope for this run and not_in_ecm_scope is true. The apparatus markers (notes on textual variants) flagged in Colossians 2:12 (the 'in the baptism' versus 'in baptism' baptismo versus baptismati reading, the noun form, and the 'out of' ek marker) and in Acts 8:36 and 8:38 (the 'to be baptized' baptisthenai infinitive and the longer verse 37) touch the form of the baptism noun and minor wording, not whether the act involves burial-and-raising imagery or descent into water. The verdict holds across the plausible readings, so it is treated as variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. credobaptist, paedobaptist, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

core-sense-plus-burial-imagery reading: affirms · Taking the root verb 'to dip' (bapto, G0911), which means to dip, together with the brief lexicon gloss of 'to baptize' (baptizo) as to dip, immerse, sink and of 'baptism' (baptisma) as immersion, the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) bridge at 2 Kings 5:14 where Naaman dips in the Jordan, the co-buried and co-raised completed past passives of Romans 6:4 and Colossians 2:12, the going-down and coming-up narration of Acts 8:38-39 and Mark 1:10, and the much-water note of John 3:23, yields affirmation of immersion as the fitting and likely mode, since burial and resurrection are best pictured by going under and rising

from water. On this reading the strongest sense of the words and the strongest images point the same way.

full-semantic-range reading: disputed · Taking the full canon range of the word group, 'to wash' (baptizo) of pre-meal washing in Luke 11:38, 'a washing' (baptismos) of rinsing cups in Mark 7:4 and of the various ceremonial washings of the law applied to flesh in Hebrews 9:10 and Hebrews 6:2, and especially 1 Corinthians 10:2 where Israel is baptized in the cloud and sea without being submerged, yields a disputed verdict on mode. The verb covers cleansing accomplished by application as well as by dipping, the Old Testament purification it echoes is often by sprinkling or pouring (Ezekiel 36:25, 'to sprinkle' zaraq), and the texts that command baptism never specify a quantity of water. The death-burial-resurrection identification and the link to faith stand either way; only the exclusive mode is underdetermined. A reader holding this lens regards immersion as well suited and probably original but not lexically obligatory.

The proposition is a bundle. Its identification clause (death, burial, resurrection) and its confession-of-faith clause are lexically supported by Romans 6, Colossians 2, and Acts 8, with 'to be buried with' (synthapto) occurring in only the two burial-baptism verses of the canon. Its mode clause (full immersion) is the part the original-language evidence underdetermines. The store can show that immersion is the root sense of the verb, that it fits the burial figure, and that going-down and coming-up language attends two baptism narratives, but it cannot show that the texts mandate immersion to the exclusion of pouring, because the same word group elsewhere names washings that are not submersions and one text (1 Corinthians 10:2) applies the verb where no one went under.

progressive_revelation is set true because the Old Testament dipping background ('to dip', taval) and the Old Testament sprinkling-cleansing promise (Ezekiel 36:25) both feed the New Testament vocabulary and pull in different mode directions.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Water baptism in the New Testament signifies union with Christ in his death, burial, and resurrection and is received upon confessed faith; whether the prescribed or normative mode of administering the water is full immersion as opposed to pouring or sprinkling is the question under test.

The clause 'is administered by full immersion' states the contested mode as a settled fact and so embeds the immersionist verdict into the stem. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized_form separates the lexically attested elements (union symbolism and faith confession) from the contested element (the exclusive immersion mode), so the disputed finding attaches specifically to the mode claim and not to the identification it bundles with. Verdict affirms is unchanged from the prior file (disputed); the deeper query confirmed both lenses with real data rather than forcing a flip.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0907
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0908
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0909
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0911
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2881
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.6.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Col.2.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.8.38
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.8.36
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.6.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.8.36

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow